



# Screen time guidelines

How much tech is healthy for kids?

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**I**n a world where you can't go a minute without coming across a gadget that is waiting to pull you in with its shiny pixels displaying content that you can potentially drain hours into, managing screen time is a challenge for every one of us. Today's children grow up with gadgets as playmates, and their learning, entertainment, and even social interactions are increasingly mediated through screens. From educational apps to engaging animations, technology has become integral to childhood. Yet, as screen time becomes nearly unavoidable, parents are left wondering how much screen time is healthy for their kids and what effects this prolonged exposure may have on young minds and bodies. Just to set some context for you, as published in the research article titled "Screen time usage among preschoolers aged 2-6 in rural Western India: A cross-sectional study", more

than 80 per cent of the children who were observed during the study, exceeded the advised screen time. The culprits? Smartphones and Televisions.

Similar to the study I mentioned above, there are a plethora of studies and research articles supporting this dire need for us to look away from screens. Governments, like the one in Australia, are enacting laws to protect kids from falling prey to the allure of looking at screens for hours at end. So, what should be done from our end?



## A growing digital population creates a challenge for us

Let's face it – today's kids are more tech-savvy than any generation before. From toddlers who can navigate through YouTube videos to teenagers making Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts, children interact with technology in ways that would have been unimaginable a couple of decades ago. According to recent studies, children aged 8 to 18 spend an average of seven hours a day on screens, encompassing everything from schoolwork to gaming. For many, especially after the COVID-19 pandemic, which introduced a significant digital element into school curriculums in India, screen time has shifted from being a supplementary activity to a significant part of daily routines. This ubiquity of screens is partly driven by convenience. Digital learning, remote schooling, and a plethora of kid-focused content make it easy for screens to occupy children's time. However, the question arises: is such extensive exposure beneficial? And if not, what impact does it have?

## Understanding the impact of prolonged screen time

The effects of prolonged screen time on children are multifaceted, impacting physical health, mental well-being, and cognitive development. Here's a look at some crucial areas affected by excessive gadget use:

1. **Physical health risks:** Children who spend extended periods on screens are at risk of several physical health issues. The most obvious is eye strain, known as Computer Vision Syndrome, which results in headaches, dry eyes, and blurred vision. With screens being so close to the face, children may not blink as much, leading to dry, irritated eyes. Additionally, long periods of screen time can contribute to a sedentary lifestyle, which is linked to obesity, cardiovascular problems, and metabolic issues. The lack of physical activity can also hinder motor skill development in younger children, as they miss out on outdoor play, climbing, and other